

Python Course: Pre-Arrival Setup

Welcome! To ensure we can dive straight into coding on the first day, please follow these instructions to install the necessary tools. Please complete these steps before the course begins.

CRITICAL FOR WINDOWS USERS:

During the Python installation process, you **MUST** check the box that says "Add Python to PATH" at the bottom of the first screen. This ensures your computer can find Python when you type commands.

1. Install Python

Python is the programming language engine. Follow these specific steps to get the correct version depending on your operating system.

Platform	Instruction & Progression Mechanics	Action / URL Target
Windows	1. Hover over the Downloads button in the main navigation banner. 2. From the menu that appears, click Windows. 3. Scroll down to the section titled "Stable Releases". 4. Under the latest Python 3 release (e.g., Python 3.12.x), click Windows installer (64-bit). 5. Run the downloaded .exe file. 6. Mandatory: Tick the box "Add Python to PATH" before clicking Install Now.	www.python.org
macOS	1. Hover over Downloads in the main banner and click macOS. 2. Under "Stable Releases", find the latest Python 3 release. 3. Click on macOS 64-bit universal2 installer. 4. Open the .pkg file and follow the standard installation prompts.	www.python.org

2. Install VS Code

Visual Studio Code is our code editor workspace environment.

Target Editor	Instruction & Purpose	Download Portal
Visual Studio Code	Click the large Download button for your specific operating system, run the installation package, and accept all default settings.	code.visualstudio.com

3. Verification (The Terminal)

Confirm your setup is ready by testing the internal terminal window built natively into VS Code.

Verification Step	Instruction & Context	Terminal Input / Output
Open Terminal	Click the Terminal menu at the very top of the VS Code window and select New Terminal .	UK Keyboard Shortcut: <code>Ctrl + `</code> (Apostrophe key)
Execute Test	In the black window that appears at the bottom, type the environment verification command string and press Enter.	<code>\$ python --version</code>
Success Check	The console environment should immediately return your active, matching version engine code deployment details.	Expected output: <code>Python 3.12.3</code> (or similar)

4. Troubleshooting System Interceptions

If running your version test commands flags a missing tool error or attempts to redirect your environment to the Microsoft Store layout, execute these mitigation overrides.

Target Issue	Instruction & Mechanics	CLI Code Override / Settings
Windows Store Redirect	Windows comes with background tracking flags that intercept terminal commands. 1. Open the Windows Start Menu , search for "Manage app execution aliases" , and select it. 2. Locate the specific toggles assigned to <code>python.exe</code> and <code>python3.exe</code> . 3. Turn both switches OFF . 4. Close and completely restart your VS Code instance to cycle tracking states.	Managed via native Windows System Options panels.
Alternative Windows Launcher	If the default engine execution flags throw path mapping errors, swap runtime targets directly to the global Windows Python Launcher shortcut asset node.	<code>\$ py --version</code> If successful, execute files using <code>py script.py</code> going forward.